The Ecommerce India Playbook

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The Ecommerce India Playbook

> ***How to sell on Amazon India, Flipkart, Meesho, ONDC and your own Shopify store — in rupees, with UPI, cash on delivery, GST invoices and zero to ¹10 lakh in sales.***

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Chapter 1: The Indian Ecommerce Landscape in 2025

Three Ways to Sell

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Model  |  Who it suits  |  Capital needed  |  Typical time to first order  |  Margin pressure
**Marketplaces** (Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho)  |  Beginners, resellers, private label  |  ¹0– ¹50,000  |  7–60 days  |  High (fees + ads + competition)
**D2C / Own store** (Shopify, WooCommerce, ONDC)  |  Brands, repeat customers, high-margin products  |  ¹30,000– ¹2,00,000  |  30–90 days  |  Medium (you own the customer)
**Hybrid** (marketplaces + own store + WhatsApp)  |  Most serious sellers  |  ¹50,000– ¹5,00,000  |  Ongoing  |  Lowest long-term
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> ***KEY INSIGHT:** The smartest Indian sellers never pick one channel. They use marketplaces for discovery (customers find you while searching) and WhatsApp/own store for repeat sales (where margin is highest). A customer who buys on Amazon today should buy from your WhatsApp catalog or Shopify store next time.*

The Big Players — What Actually Matters to You

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Indian Buyer Behavior You Must Internalize

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Chapter 2: Choosing Your Ecommerce Model

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The Four Models Compared

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The Decision Framework

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> ***PRO TIP:** If you're unsure, start on Meesho with ¹0 investment to learn the mechanics (catalogs, orders, shipping labels, customer service), then graduate to Amazon/Shopify with whatever you learned. Meesho is your free ecommerce school.*

Chapter 3: Amazon India Masterclass

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Step 1: Register Your Seller Account

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> ***WARNING:** Your Amazon account is tied to your GSTIN and PAN. Selling on multiple accounts or using fake GST is the #1 way sellers get permanently banned. One account, done right.*

Step 2: Understand the Fee Stack

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```
Fee type  |  Typical range  |  Notes
Referral fee  |  5–20% of sale price  |  Category-dependent; beauty ~10%, electronics ~5–8%
FBA fulfillment fee  |  ¹40– ¹150+ per unit  |  Depends on size/weight tier and your selling price
Closing fee  |  ~ ¹0– ¹25  |  Small fixed fee on some categories
Storage fee  |  Monthly  |  Peak Oct–Dec fees are brutal
Advertising (Sponsored Products)  |  ¹0–15% of sales  |  You set bids; no spend = no visibility in search
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Step 3: Create a Listing That Ranks

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Step 4: FBA vs FBM — The Core Decision

```
Factor  |  FBA (Fulfilled by Amazon)  |  FBM (Fulfilled by Merchant)
Delivery speed  |  1–3 days, Prime badge  |  You control; 3–7 days typical
Buy Box win rate  |  Much higher  |  Lower unless price-competitive
Fees  |  FBA fee per unit  |  No FBA fee, but you pay shipping
Returns handling  |  Amazon manages  |  You manage — painful
Best for  |  Fast movers, light products  |  Heavy/bulky, slow movers, high-value
```

> ***KEY INSIGHT:** On Amazon India, FBA is usually worth it for products under 2 kg that sell weekly. Heavy or slow-moving items bleed money in FBA storage fees — use FBM and Shiprocket instead.*

Step 5: Ads That Don't Burn Cash

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Step 6: Returns, Ratings and Account Health

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Chapter 4: Selling on Flipkart

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Registration & Setup

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Where Flipkart Wins

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Flipkart-Specific Tactics

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***PRO TIP:** Launch on Flipkart first to learn marketplace basics with less complexity, then graduate to Amazon where the stakes — and rewards — are higher.*

Chapter 5: Meesho — The Zero-Investment Reseller's Game

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The Two Meesho Models

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How to Succeed as a Meesho Reseller

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Meesho for Serious Sellers

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***WARNING:** Meesho's reseller model is a *learning tool*, not a business. Margins of ¹50–150 per order don't scale without an enormous network. Use it to learn product research and order management — then move to private label or D2C where you control product and margin.*

Chapter 6: ONDC — The Open Network for Digital Commerce

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What ONDC Actually Is

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Who Should Sell on ONDC?

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How to Get Started

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ONDC Limitations (Be Honest)

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> ***KEY INSIGHT:** ONDC is not a replacement for marketplaces — it's a margin-protection layer. The winning strategy is: sell on Amazon/Flipkart for volume, sell on ONDC for margin, sell on Shopify/ WhatsApp for repeat customers.*

Chapter 7: Building Your Own Shopify Store for India

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Why Shopify for India?

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The India-Specific Setup

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Step-by-Step: Shopify Store Launch in 30 Days

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> ***PRO TIP:** Don't launch with 100 products. Launch with 5–10 hero products you can actually fulfill well.*

Chapter 8: WhatsApp Commerce — India's Secret Sales Channel

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WhatsApp Business Setup

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WhatsApp as a Sales Funnel

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WhatsApp Sales Scripts That Work

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"Hi! Thanks for your interest in [Product]. It's ¹[Price] with free shipping. Would you like the payment link or COD?"

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"Hi [Name], just checking — did you get a chance to look at [Product]? I have a special offer this week: [Discount]. Want me to book an order for you?"

[object Object]
"Thanks for your order! Order #[ID] confirmed. We'll ship within 24 hours. Track here: [Link]. COD amount: ¹[Amount]."

***KEY INSIGHT:** WhatsApp converts better than any other channel in India because it's personal, instant, and trusted. A customer who messages you is 3x more likely to buy than one who visits your website cold.*

Chapter 9: Pricing & Margin Math in INR

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The Golden Formula

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Worked Example 1: Amazon FBA Product

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```
Cost item  |  Amount
Product cost (from manufacturer)  |   ¹180
Shipping to Amazon warehouse  |   ¹30
Amazon referral fee (10%)  |   ¹50
FBA fulfillment fee  |   ¹70
Ad spend (10% of sales)  |   ¹50
Returns reserve (5%)  |   ¹25
**Total cost**  |  ** ¹405**
**Selling price**  |  ** ¹599**
**Profit per order**  |  ** ¹194 (32% margin)**
```

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Worked Example 2: Meesho Reseller

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```
Cost item  |  Amount
Product cost (from supplier)  |   ¹180
Meesho commission  |   ¹20
Shipping (handled by Meesho)  |   ¹0
**Total cost**  |  ** ¹200**
**Selling price**  |  ** ¹299**
**Profit per order**  |  ** ¹99 (33% margin)**
```

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Worked Example 3: Shopify D2C Product

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```
Cost item  |  Amount
Product cost  |  ¹250
Packaging  |  ¹30
Shipping (Delhivery Surface)  |  ¹50
Payment gateway (Razorpay 2%)  |  ¹20
COD fee (if COD order)  |  ¹10
Meta ads (15% of sales)  |  ¹75
Returns reserve (10%)  |  ¹50
**Total cost**  |  ** ¹485**
**Selling price**  |  ** ¹799**
**Profit per order**  |  ** ¹314 (39% margin)**
```

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INR Pricing Psychology

```
Technique  |  Example  |  Why it works
Charm pricing  |  ¹999 vs  ¹1,000  |  Perceived as significantly cheaper
Anchoring  |  "Was  ¹1,499, now  ¹999"  |  Shows value, creates urgency
Bundle pricing  |  "Buy 2, get 10% off"  |  Increases AOV (average order value)
EMI display  |  " ¹499/month × 3"  |  Makes expensive products feel affordable
Free shipping threshold  |  "Free shipping on orders above  ¹499"  |  Increases order value
Price ending in 9  |  ¹499,  ¹999,  ¹1,499  |  Signals deal/bargain
```

> ***PRO TIP:** Always calculate your **break-even price** before setting a selling price. If your break-even is ¹450, never sell below ¹499 — you'll lose money on every order.*

Chapter 10: Logistics & Shipping Stack

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Indian Logistics Players

```
Provider  |  Best for  |  Strengths  |  Weaknesses
**Delhivery**  |  Marketplaces, bulk shipping  |  Largest network, reliable, cheap Surface option  |  Can be slow on Surface (4–7 days)
**BlueDart**  |  Premium, urgent, high-value  |  Fastest, best tracking, reliable  |  Expensive (~ ¹80–150 for 500g)
**XpressBees**  |  D2C, quick commerce  |  Fast, good for metro delivery  |  Limited rural reach
**Shiprocket**  |  Aggregator for all  |  One integration, rate shopping, COD management  |  Adds ~5–10% markup on shipping
**Delhivery Surface**  |  Economy, non-urgent  |  Cheapest (~ ¹30–50 for 500g)  |  Slow (4–7 days), basic tracking
**India Post**  |  Cheapest, rural  |  Reaches everywhere, very cheap  |  Slow, unreliable, poor tracking
```

Shipping Cost Examples (500g, Delhi to Mumbai)

```
Provider  |  Cost  |  Delivery time
Delhivery Surface  |  ¹35–45  |  4–6 days
Delhivery Express  |  ¹70–90  |  2–3 days
BlueDart  |  ¹90–120  |  1–2 days
Shiprocket (rate-shopped)  |  ¹50–80  |  2–4 days
```

The Smart Shipping Stack

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> ***KEY INSIGHT:** Indian buyers are extremely sensitive to shipping cost and speed. A ¹50 shipping fee can kill a ¹299 order. Either offer free shipping (build into product price) or offer it above a threshold.*

Chapter 11: Marketing for Indian Buyers

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Meta Ads (Facebook/Instagram) for India

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Influencer Marketing in India

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Telegram & WhatsApp Groups

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Organic Marketing That Works

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> ***PRO TIP:** In India, the best marketing is often offline — local markets, exhibitions, college fests, and word-of-mouth still drive significant ecommerce sales. Don't ignore them.*

Chapter 12: GST, Invoicing & Compliance Basics

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Do You Need GST Registration?

```
Annual turnover  |  GST registration required?  |  Notes
Below  ¹40 lakh (goods)  |  No  |  Can sell without GST
 ¹40 lakh+ (goods)  |  Yes  |  Mandatory
Below  ¹20 lakh (services)  |  No  |  Can sell without GST
 ¹20 lakh+ (services)  |  Yes  |  Mandatory
Interstate sales  |  Yes  |  Must register regardless of turnover
Marketplace sellers  |  Effectively yes  |  Amazon/Flipkart require GSTIN for most categories
```

GST Slabs for Common Products

```
Product category  |  GST rate  |  Example
Food, fresh produce  |  0–5%  |  Fruits, vegetables, packaged food
Textiles, apparel  |  5–12%  |  Kurtis, sarees, t-shirts
Electronics  |  18%  |  Phones, accessories, gadgets
Beauty, cosmetics  |  18%  |  Skin care, makeup
Home decor  |  18%  |  Lamps, wall art, furniture
Luxury items  |  28%  |  Watches, premium goods
```

Invoicing Requirements

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Other Compliance Basics

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> ***WARNING:** Selling without required licenses can mean penalties, account suspension, and legal action. Check requirements for your product category before launching.*

Chapter 13: Going International from India

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Why Sell Internationally?

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Cross-Border Platforms

```
Platform  |  Best for  |  Fees  |  Notes
**Amazon Global Selling**  |  Amazon sellers expanding  |  ~15–25% referral + FBA  |  Easiest for existing Amazon sellers
**Etsy**  |  Handicrafts, jewelry, vintage, art  |  ~6.5% transaction + listing  |  Handmade/vintage niche
**Shopify + intl. shipping**  |  D2C brands  |  Gateway + shipping  |  Full control, higher complexity
**eBay**  |  General merchandise  |  ~10–13% final value fee  |  Auction + fixed price
```

Cross-Border Basics

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What Sells Well from India

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***PRO TIP:** Start international with Etsy or Amazon Global Selling — they handle customs, payments, and customer service better than a standalone store. Graduate to Shopify international when you have volume.*

Chapter 14: Common Mistakes That Kill Indian Stores

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Mistake 1: Ignoring the Fee Stack

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Mistake 2: Underpricing to "Get Sales"

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Mistake 3: No COD Strategy

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Mistake 4: Ignoring Returns

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Mistake 5: No Customer Service

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Mistake 6: Copying Western Ecommerce Advice

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Mistake 7: GST Non-Compliance

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Mistake 8: No Repeat Purchase Strategy

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Mistake 9: Over-Reliance on One Channel

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Mistake 10: Giving Up Too Early

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Chapter 15: 90-Day Launch Roadmap

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Days 1–30: Foundation

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Days 31–60: Growth

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Days 61–90: Scale & Systematize

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Chapter 16: Capstone — Pick a Product and Plan a ¹0-to-¹1L Store

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Step 1: Product Selection Criteria

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Step 2: Product Research Method

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Step 3: Financial Projection for ¹1L/Month

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Step 4: Your 90-Day Action Plan

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Step 5: Your Daily Routine (Once Launched)

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***KEY INSIGHT:** The difference between a ¹10,000/month store and a ¹1,00,000/month store isn't the product — it's consistency. The sellers who win are the ones who show up every day, optimize weekly, and never quit.*

Chapter 17: Final Checklist — Are You Ready?

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Business Foundation

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Platform Setup

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Product Readiness

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Marketing & Sales

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Going Further

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